The show's protagonist is a Syrian Christian living in Ratlam. "This is a community that we don't see often on our screens. I was a Maharashtrian who grew up in MP, so I understand what it is like to grow up with two different cultural identities." As for setting the show in Ratlam, Kirkire believes that the small railway town is cosmopolitan enough that "a Mariam can collaborate with someone like Robo".

Kirkire's career in the movies started with Sudhir Mishra's *Hazaaron Khwaishein Aisi* (2003), where he was credited as an assistant director, singer and lyricist (of 'Baawra Mann') and actor. In the years since, he's continued to work in multiple capacities. This year is going to be no different. Kirkire is acting alongside Jaya Bachchan in Vikas Bahl's *Dil Ka Darwaaza Khol Na Darling* and in Sooraj Bharjatya's next. He is writing a song for Rohit Shetty's next and has also recently released a slew of singles. Having trained in direction from National School of Drama, he's hoping to add that to his repertoire soon. "For some reason, direction just hasn't happened in all of these years. It'll happen when it's supposed to happen." ■

—Karishma Upadhyay

New Lease to Tradition

Ahead of his Qutub Minar performance, flautist Rakesh Chaurasia on his journey making classical music resonate with new generations

On March 8, the centuries-old silhouette of the Qutub Minar will find a new voice. The second chapter of *Songs of the Stone*—the cultural series by Inkpot India, founded by Simar Malhotra and presented in collaboration with HSBC Live the Legacy—will see two-time Grammy Award-winning flautist Rakesh Chaurasia and his ensemble Rakesh and Friends perform against a backdrop where history itself becomes part of the experience. "When heritage music meets a heritage monument, people don't just listen; they feel it," he says.

The evening mirrors a journey Chaurasia has been shaping for nearly a decade. His band—bringing together tabla, drums, bass, guitar and keys—started with the realisation that younger listeners often found classical music distant. "But this is our inherited music," he says. "If we don't bring it to the next generation, who will?"

For Chaurasia, classical music shouldn't be preserved behind glass; it is the grammar that underpins everything else. Whether in film scores or global collaborations, he believes the purity always stems from a classical base. He aims not to dilute the form but rethink how it is presented. Unlike conventional fusion, where a raga may simply lead while the band follows, Chaurasia's process is more deliberate. "We sit for hours composing within the raga," he explains. "So, someone with knowledge enjoys it, and someone just listening also enjoys it."

Balancing accessibility and authenticity comes from lineage. As the nephew and disciple of Hariprasad Chaurasia, he grew up under the weight of expectation. "It's a heavy branch on your shoulder," he admits.

> THE AIM IS NOT TO DILUTE THE FORM BUT RETHINK ITS PRESENTATION, TO BE MORE THAN A RAGA SIMPLY LEADING THE BAND

Yet his guru gave him the freedom to explore beyond traditional boundaries. Chaurasia remains focused on how music reaches people through new compositions. "Music should grow," he says. "We shouldn't put boundaries around it." ■

—Geetika Sachdev



The ensemble (clockwise): Gino Banks, Sheldon D'Silva, Sangeet Haldipur, Sanjoy Das, Satyajit Talwakar, Rakesh Chaurasia